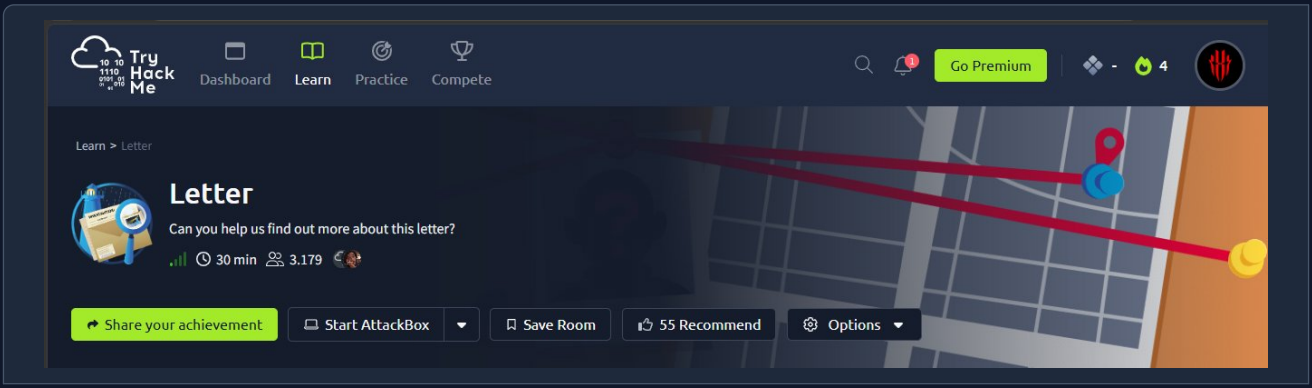
LETTER

CTF Writeup — TryHackMe

Platform	TryHackMe
Room	Letter
Category	OSINT / Intelligence
Points	60
Status	COMPLETED
Author	RedWarrior
Date	April 21, 2026



TryHackMe — Letter room overview

SECTION 1 Concept

Open-source intelligence (OSINT) challenge. Physical artefacts — a letter envelope and an old newspaper clipping — contain encoded and contextual clues that, when decoded and cross-referenced with public historical records, reveal a full name, age, and a CTF flag.

SECTION 2 Context

TryHackMe room named **Letter**. The task file contains three artefacts: a scanned envelope (French postal letter), a scanned newspaper clipping (*L'Ouest-Éclair*), and a text file written in French. The objective is to answer two questions using only the information present in those files.

Task files: envelope (left) and newspaper clipping (right)

SECTION 3 Exploitation Steps

STEP 1 Downloaded and Reviewed Task Files

I downloaded the task archive. It contained three files: an image of the envelope, an image of an old newspaper clipping, and a French text file (Note.txt).

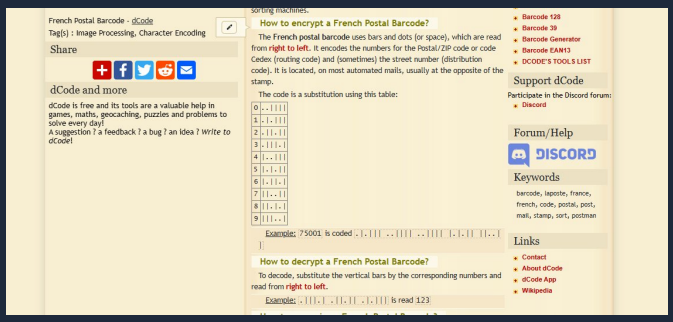
STEP 2 Read the Text File — Extracted Clues

I read the text file carefully and extracted three key phrases:

- "je suis tombée sur cette vieille coupure de journal" — a direct reference to the old newspaper clipping.
- "l'âge de passer le permis" — I noted this means the person is under 18 (legal driving age in France).
- "de te voir sur l'eau à ton tour" — I understood the activity was water-related, likely the sea.

STEP 3 Decoded the French Postal Barcode on the Envelope

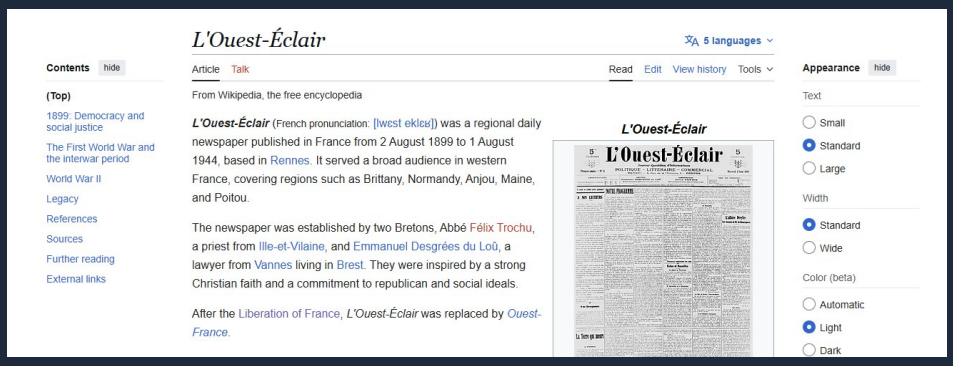
I noticed a sequence of bars and dots printed at the bottom of the envelope. I searched for the French postal barcode system and found that it uses a substitution table of bars and dots read from right to left. I used dcode.fr/french-postal-barcode to decode it manually following the table provided. Reading the result from right to left as instructed, I obtained the postal code 29760.



dcode.fr — French postal barcode decoding table I used to decode the envelope barcode

STEP 4 Identified the Newspaper — L'Ouest-Éclair

I searched for the newspaper name visible in the clipping: *L'Ouest-Éclair*. I found on Wikipedia that it was a French regional daily newspaper published from 1899 to 1944, based in Rennes. After the Liberation of France it was replaced by *Ouest-France*. This told me the clipping had to date from before 1944.



Wikipedia — I found confirmation that L'Ouest-Éclair ran from 1899 to 1944

STEP 5 Found the Exact Edition Date — Gallica Archive

I used Gemini to analyse the visible headlines and narrow the approximate date. It returned 24 May 1925. I then searched the Gallica (BnF) digital archive using that date and located the exact edition: gallica.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/bpt6k648015m/f1.image.

Gallica archive — I located the L'Ouest-Éclair edition dated 24 May 1925

STEP 6 Read the Article — Catastrophe of Penmarch

I identified the relevant section in the newspaper. The second column from the left is titled **"Une catastrophe sur les côtes du Finistère"**. I read the article and found it described a maritime disaster off the coast of Penmarch in which 26 men drowned — matching the water-related clue in the text file.

Une catastrophe sur les côtes du Finistère

DEUX BATEAUX DE PECHE EN PERDITION ET DEUX CANOTS DE SAUVETAGE SOMBRENT AU LARGE DE PENMARCH

Vingt-six hommes sont noyés

Une épouvantable catastrophe vient de jeter la consternation sur nos côtes bretonnes et de semer le deuil parmi les populations : Un affreux drame de la mer s'est déroulé au large de la pointe de Penmarch; 26 hommes sont noyés.

Voici la dépêche que nous avons reçue à ce sujet :

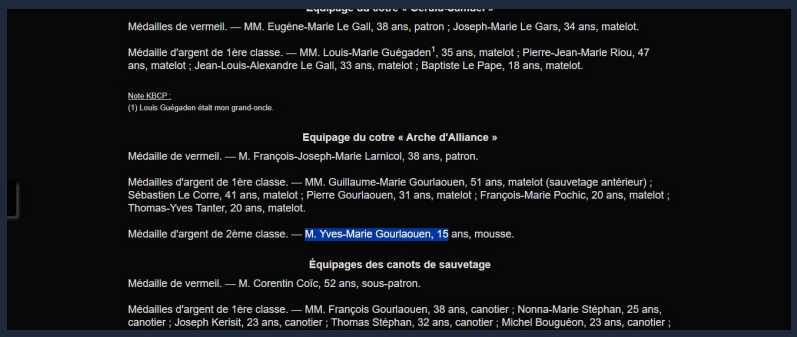
QUIMPER, 23 mai (*De notre correspondant particulier*). — Aujourd'hui, vers 14 heures, deux bateaux de pêche montés, l'un par 7 hommes et l'autre par 5, se trouvaient en perdition au large de Saint-Pierre-Penmarch.

Les canots de la station de sauvetage prévenus immédiatement, prirent la mer et allèrent à leur secours. Chaque canot

L'Ouest-Éclair — the article I found about the Penmarch maritime disaster (26 men drowned)

STEP 7 Found the Name and Age of the Person

I searched online for the full medal recipient list linked to the Penmarch disaster. I went through every name and age on the list looking for the only person under 18, consistent with the clue about the driving age. I found: Yves-Marie Gourlaouen, 15 ans, mousse — crew member of the cutter *Arche d'Alliance*, awarded a Médaille d'argent de 2ème classe. He was the only person under 18 in the entire list.



Médailles de vermeil. — MM. Eugène-Marie Le Gall, 38 ans, patron ; Joseph-Marie Le Gars, 34 ans, matelot.

Médaille d'argent de 1ère classe. — MM. Louis-Marie Guégaden[1], 35 ans, matelot ; Pierre-Jean-Marie Riou, 47 ans, matelot ; Jean-Louis-Alexandre Le Gall, 33 ans, matelot ; Baptiste Le Pape, 18 ans, matelot.

Note KBCP :
(1) Louis Guégaden était mon grand-oncle.

Equipage du cotre « Arche d'Alliance »

Médaille de vermeil. — M. François-Joseph-Marie Larnicol, 38 ans, patron.

Médailles d'argent de 1ère classe. — MM. Guillaume-Marie Gourlaouen, 51 ans, matelot (sauvetage antérieur) ; Sébastien Le Corre, 41 ans, matelot ; Pierre Gourlaouen, 31 ans, matelot ; François-Marie Pochic, 20 ans, matelot ; Thomas-Yves Tanter, 20 ans, matelot.

Médaille d'argent de 2ème classe. — M. Yves-Marie Gourlaouen, 15 ans, mousse.

Équipages des canots de sauvetage

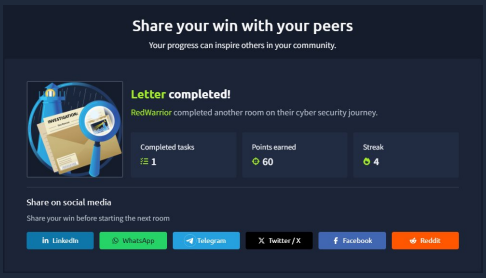
Médaille de vermeil. — M. Corentin Coïc, 52 ans, sous-patron.

Médailles d'argent de 1ère classe. — MM. François Gourlaouen, 38 ans, canotier ; Nonna-Marie Stéphan, 25 ans, canotier ; Joseph Kerisit, 23 ans, canotier ; Thomas Stéphan, 32 ans, canotier ; Michel Bouguéon, 23 ans, canotier ;

Medal recipient list — I identified Yves-Marie Gourlaouen, 15 ans, as the only person under 18

SECTION 4 Result

Question 1	Postal code of the delivery address
Answer 1	29760
Question 2	Full name and age of the person mentioned in the note
Answer 2	Yves-Marie Gourlaouen, 15 years old
Flag	THM{Yves-Marie_Gourlaouen_15}
Points earned	60



TryHackMe — Letter room completed (60 points)

SECTION 5 Technical Explanation

FRENCH POSTAL BARCODE

I found that the French postal barcode encodes the postal/ZIP code using a substitution table of bars and dots. The code is read from right to left. Each digit (0–9) maps to a specific pattern of vertical bars and dots. I decoded it manually using the table at dcode.fr and read the result right to left, which gave me postal code 29760.

NEWSPAPER DATE IDENTIFICATION

I searched for L'Ouest-Éclair and found it was published between 1899 and 1944. I then used Gemini to analyse the visible headlines — "Amundsen a-t-il atteint le pôle Nord?" and "Les événements du Maroc" — and it pointed me to 24 May 1925. I confirmed this by opening the Gallica digital archive of the Bibliothèque nationale de France.

OSINT CLUE CHAIN

I read the text file and connected the three clues: the newspaper clipping, a person below driving age, and a water-related activity. I searched the Penmarch maritime disaster of 23 May 1925 and went through the medal recipient list. I identified Yves-Marie Gourlaouen, aged 15, as the only person under 18 — a cabin boy (mousse) on the cutter Arche d'Alliance.